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Research Article

Creaming among Caseworkers: Effects of Client Competence and Client Motivation on Caseworkers' Willingness to Help

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Abstract: *Frontline employees cope with high workloads and limited resources by directing their work attention and efforts toward particular clients. Yet, the role of client attributes in frontline employees' efforts to help clients remains undertheorized and empirically understudied. Using a survey experimental vignette design (2 × 2 factorial) among 1,595 Danish caseworkers, the authors of this article provide new knowledge on how two generic nondemographic client attributes—competence and motivation—shape frontline employees' willingness to help their clients. We found that both the competence and motivation of clients affect caseworkers' willingness to exert extra time and effort helping clients. Specifically, caseworkers are most willing to help a client appearing both competent and motivated. Moreover, our data suggests that client motivation is more important than client competence for caseworkers' willingness to help. We end the article with a discussion of policy implications and directions for future research.*

Evidence for Practice

- Nondemographic client attributes—competence and motivation—affect caseworkers' willingness to exert extra time and effort to serve a particular client.
- Client motivation has a larger effect than client competence on caseworkers' willingness to spend extra time and effort helping clients.
- For ensuring that citizens receive fair and equitable public service, public managers must be cognizant of the various client attributes influencing frontline employees' behavior and decision-making.

A large group of public employees are "street-level bureaucrats" (Lipsky 1980), frontline employees interacting directly and frequently with citizens and having substantial discretion in the execution of their work (Gofen 2013; Hupe and Hill 2007; Thomann, Van Engen, and Tummers 2018). Frontline employees operate in the context of cross-pressure. They face the challenge of having limited available resources to perform their work while experiencing interminable client demands for services. To obviate insurmountable workloads and psychological exhaustion, frontline employees are therefore compelled to use what Lipsky (1980) calls "coping mechanisms." In particular, frontline employees may resort to a coping strategy involving "cream-skimming" (Lipsky 1980; Tummers 2016; Verdung 2015; Winter and Nielsen 2008). Using this strategy, frontline employees selectively focus their attention and efforts on those of their clients who exhibit the best prognoses for achievement of substantive policy goals (e.g., the greatest likelihood of rapid recovery, successful rehabilitation, or high performance).

Although frontline employees' focus on particular clients serves as a means to cope with high workloads and limited resources, the exercise of more help to particular clients constitutes an issue of scholarly attention and societal concern. In some policy areas, frontline employees have formal authority to direct their attention and efforts at particular clients, such as those most in need or first in line. Yet, "creaming" does not form a legitimate basis for helping some client more than others. Except for rare cases (e.g., triage), differences in willingness to help clients based on creaming considerations constitute a break with administrative principles of equity and impartiality that are not supported by formal rules and regulations and that may result in unequal treatment of citizens (for recent discussions, see Battaglio and Hall 2018; Gooden 2015).

This article expands our knowledge about the factors shaping frontline employees' willingness to help particular clients. In line with public administration research on how client race and ethnicity affect behavior and decision-making (Grohs, Adam, and Knill 2016; Jilke, Van Dooren, and Rys 2018; Pedersen, Stritch, and Thuesen 2018), creaming among caseworkers may ensue based on clients' demographic

characteristics. However, more research into the attributes of clients whom frontline employees choose to help over other clients is needed. In particular, the role of nondemographic client attributes, such as competence and motivation, in frontline employees' willingness to help clients remains undertheorized and empirically understudied (for an exception, see Jilke and Tummers 2018). This is striking as competence and motivation are broadly recognized as key determinants of individual behavior and performance (Marin-Garcia and Tomas 2016). Achieving a more complete understanding of what and how client attributes shape frontline employees' willingness to help their clients is both of scholarly relevance and practical importance. Ultimately, frontline employees' behaviors add up to agency policy (Lipsky 1980).

At least two strands of research touch on the question of how frontline employees' willingness to help may differ across clients, but the two strands yield conflicting theoretical expectations. One strand of research suggests that frontline employees seek to reduce caseloads or improve performance ratings by prioritizing "easy" clients, that is, those with the highest likelihood of policy success (Tummers 2016; Van Berkel and Knies 2016). Say that the behavior of caseworkers dealing with unemployed clients is rooted primarily in such creaming considerations. We may then expect caseworkers to expend more effort toward helping clients whom they perceive as competent (as these clients are more likely to find employment quickly). Another strand of research suggests that frontline employees' assessment of clients' deservingness is the primary determinant of their decision-making (Schram et al. 2009). In contrast to the former perspective, this research expects that the behavior of caseworkers is driven mainly by deservingness considerations. We may then expect clients' competence to be of lesser importance, whereas other client attributes, such as their motivation, may be of greater importance. Although studies show that frontline employees cream in some instances (e.g., Tummers 2016) and rely on deservingness heuristics in others (e.g., Schram et al. 2009), we lack research examining the role of nondemographic client attributes for frontline employees' willingness to help clients.

This article examines how clients' competence and motivation, as well as the interplay between these client attributes, influence frontline employees' willingness to exert extra time and effort helping clients. Our inquiry builds on recent research demonstrating that frontline employees' perception of a client's effort (related to motivation) and performance (related to competence) influences employees' decision to prioritize helping that client (Jilke and Tummers 2018).[1] Expanding on these insights, this article theorizes and tests how the interplay of clients' attributes affects frontline employees' willingness to help their clients. In real life, clients exhibit attributes related to both their competence and motivation, and the interplay of the two attributes may affect how frontline employees perceive and treat clients. This article theorizes that frontline employees' decisions to exert extra time and effort to help particular clients are the product of a potential interplay between different client attributes. When caseworkers interact with and assess a client, this article argues that they do consider individual client attributes but that their assessments are shaped also by general impressions of that client—an overall mental picture in which one client attribute may affect the influence of another.

The article derives theoretical expectations from research suggesting how frontline employees can be considered either as "citizen agents," where behavior is guided mostly by perception of client deservingness, or as "state agents," where behavior is guided more by following the rules and self-interest (Maynard-Moody and Musheno 2000, 2003). Integrating the two perspectives, the article builds a theoretical model emphasizing how the interplay of client attributes may shape frontline employees' willingness to help particular clients. Although frontline employees may pay extra attention to less competent clients or less motivated clients, incompetent clients exhibiting low motivation do not align with either the citizen agent or the state agent narrative. Therefore, we theorize that a client perceived as both incompetent and unmotivated is seen neither as deserving of receiving extra help nor as more likely to succeed. Relative to the incompetent and unmotivated client, frontline employees will therefore tend to prioritize clients whom they perceive either as competent but unmotivated or as incompetent but motivated. Similarly, based on both the citizen-agent and the state-agent narratives, we expect frontline employees to be more willing to help competent and motivated clients over other types of clients. In the mixed cases, we recognize how caseworkers' willingness to help a particular client depends on whether frontline employees act primarily as citizen agents or state agents (Wenger and Wilkins 2009). Still, because the state-agent perspective ascribes relatively greater importance to motivation than the citizen-agent perspective does to competence, the article theorizes that frontline employees will tend to prioritize incompetent but motivated clients over competent but unmotivated clients.

The article tests the theoretical model using a 2×2 factorial survey experimental design among a sample of 1,595 unemployment caseworkers in Denmark. Using this design, we examine how variation in a client's competence and motivation affect caseworker willingness to exert extra time and effort to help that client back into employment (at the expense of time to help other clients). The analysis shows that both competence and motivation affect caseworkers' inclinations to help a client in line with the theoretical model and expectations. The article provides novel evidence showing that caseworkers are more willing to help a motivated than an unmotivated client regardless of the client's job competence. However, whereas caseworkers are more willing to help incompetent but motivated clients compared to competent but unmotivated clients, caseworkers are even more willing to help a client who is both competent and motivated.

The article proceeds as follows. First, it develops a theoretical model integrating knowledge about street-level bureaucratic behavior and willingness to help particular clients. The article uses the model for deriving hypotheses about the role of clients' competence and clients' motivation in how frontline employees are willing to expend extra time and effort helping clients. Second, the article discusses the empirical setting and the research design. Third, the results of the analyses follow. Finally, the article discusses the limitations before concluding on the implications of the findings for how we may understand citizen-state interactions and frontline employees' willingness to help clients.

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Theory

According to Lipsky (1980), frontline employees must navigate in organizations facing higher demands for services than can realistically be delivered with the available resources. Consequently, frontline employees use coping strategies that facilitate the decision-making process and help them manage their workloads. One important strategy, "rationing of output," entails having frontline employees selectively choose particular clients or tasks on which to focus their time and energy. Studies show that frontline employees are inclined to cream, that is, prioritize clients whom they perceive as the most likely to succeed. Tummers (2016) finds that frontline employees who report higher levels of creaming behavior receive higher performance ratings by their managers—indicating that frontline employees are creaming clients to improve performance ratings. Similarly, other research suggests that the implementation of accountability measures in public organizations may have further incentivized creaming among caseworkers (Soss, Fording, and Schram 2011). Also, van Loon and Jakobsen (2017) show that higher levels of perceived work pressure correlates with higher levels of client-oriented coping behavior. Although creaming may serve instrumental purposes that are "necessary to maintain the organization, even though the procedures may be contrary to agency policy" (Lipsky 1980, 19), it often entails that the strongest clients are prioritized at the expense of the weaker clients—those who are less likely to succeed. However, to what extent and how do clients' nondemographic attributes, such as competence and motivation, induce frontline employees to exert extra time and effort helping some clients at the cost of deprioritizing others? This question remains largely unexamined in the literature.

An emerging experimental literature demonstrates how client attributes—in particular, regarding race and ethnicity—affect frontline employees' treatment of clients (Andersen and Guul 2019; Petersen 2019; Pedersen, Stritch, and Thuesen 2018), frontline employees prioritization of response to clients' requests (Einstein and Glick 2017; White, Nathan, and Faller 2015), and the quality of answers frontline employees provide (Hemker and Rink 2017). However, other studies find no difference in treatment for race and ethnicity in public agency settings (Grohs, Adam, and Knill 2016; Jilke, Van Dooren, and Rys 2018). The mixed findings may be a function of multiple factors, including differences in incentives to discriminate across study settings. We argue, however, that one potentially contributing factor relates to the interdependency between client characteristics. Frontline employees' reaction to one client characteristic may depend on other client attributes that modify the perception of the clients (Hemker and Rink 2017; Schram et al. 2009). Taking account of how frontline employees' behavior is shaped by the interplay between client attributes is thus important.[2] More complete and nuanced understanding of how client attributes influence frontline employees' decision-making must consider how caseworkers' perception and assessments of clients are shaped not only by individual client attributes but also by a general impression of that client—an overall mental picture in which one client attribute may affect the influence of another.

While our understanding of racial and ethnic biases has expanded in recent years, few studies have examined how nondemographic client attributes, such as competence and motivation, influence frontline employees' behavior and decision-making. Despite the lack of research, some studies argue that these nondemographic client attributes might be a main underlying explanation for differential treatment of clients. For example, Jilke and Tummers (2018) theorize that frontline employees' perception of clients' effort (motivation) and performance (competence) influences employees' prioritization of clients. Jilke and Tummers (2018) propose that frontline employees' decision to prioritize is derived from clients' exhibition of high effort ("earned deservingness"), exhibition of low performance ("needed deservingness"), or exhibition of high performance ("resource deservingness"). However, their theoretical model and hypotheses suggest that frontline employees prioritize both the lowest performing clients because these clients have the highest potential for improvement (needed deservingness) and the highest performing clients, who are most likely to succeed (resource deservingness). Moreover, their model does not consider the potential interplay between client attributes.

In the following, the article draws on the state-agent and citizen-agent perspectives (Maynard-Moody and Musheno 2000) and theorizes on how different client attributes condition the effect of other client attributes and, thereby, how the interplay of client attributes may be a component for understanding the effects of client attributes on frontline employees' willingness to help particular clients.

Theoretical Model

Frontline employees have different guides of behavior. According to Maynard-Moody and Musheno (2000), frontline employees can be perceived as state agents, that is, agents whose behavior is guided primarily by following rules and self-interest that induce them to use their discretion for making their work "easier, safer, and more rewarding" (339). Frontline employees do so by "focusing on easier clients, and by avoiding, dismissing, or reducing contact with the unpleasant or impossible cases" (339). This state-agent guide of behavior stands opposite to a citizen-agent narrative. From this perspective, frontline employees choose their work and profession based on a profound interest in delivering high-quality public services to people in need. According to the citizen-agent perspective, the primary guide of behavior concerns whether the client is deserving of extra help (Maynard-Moody and Musheno 2000). Both perspectives ground theoretical expectations emphasizing that the behavior of frontline employees depends on clients' attributes. In the following, we first consider the two perspectives separately—the approach of previous studies (Jilke and Tummers 2018; Tummers 2016)—before moving on to theorize about the combination of the two perspectives.

Following the first logic, the two perspectives suggest that client attributes of competence and motivation are important and assessable in interactions between frontline employees and clients. According to the state-agent perspective, however, clients' competence affects the likelihood of policy success. Clients' competence is viewed, therefore, as more important than their motivation. In contrast, the citizen-agent perspective emphasizes the importance of the perceived deservingness of clients, with deservingness perceptions often based on assumptions about clients' motivation (Cosmides and Tooby 1992; Gilens 1999; Hauser et al. 2003; Petersen et al. 2011). Regarding the latter, Jilke and Tummers (2018) show how frontline employees are more likely to prioritize motivated

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clients because these clients are perceived as more deserving. Although client motivation is mostly associated with the concept of deservingness (Petersen 2012; Schram et al. 2009), we also expect that frontline employees' self-interest (and, thus, their state-agent–guided behavior) makes them more willing to help motivated clients because motivated clients are also more likely to succeed. Looking at the attributes separately, as has so far been the primary approach in the literature, therefore leads to expectations about the relationship between clients' attributes and frontline employees' willingness to help particular clients: Frontline employees tend to be more willing to help competent clients and motivated clients depending on whether they are considered state or citizen agents.

This article argues that frontline employees act following a combination of state-agent and citizen-agent guides of behavior rather than one of the two narratives at a time. Because frontline employees' perceptions of clients are formed by a multitude of client attributes, focusing on single attributes can be necessary in order to reduce complexity. However, research indicates that some attributes are activated by others. For example, Schram et al. (2009) find effects of client race on frontline employees' decision-making, but only when the respondents are exposed simultaneously to a negative cue verifying stereotypes. Therefore, we expect the two perspectives to operate simultaneously, with the relative strength of each narrative potentially varying across individuals and policy contexts. In other words, when frontline employees interact with clients, they do not necessarily react to single attributes. Different client attributes may modify or condition perceptions of other client attributes. Consequently, we need to examine how the interplay of client attributes influences frontline employees' client perception as the overall mental picture of clients' likelihood of policy success and deservingness may be shaped by the combination of attributes. For example, when school teachers decide which students they should spend additional time helping, they are not only assessing the students' competence but also their motivation. Jilke and Tummers (2018) hypothesize that high client performance (earned deservingness) increases the likelihood that frontline employees prioritize a client—which may be true on the average. Adding to this insight, we theorize that whether the client achieved a high performance through hard work (motivation), talent, or sheer luck may condition whether the earned deservingness matters or not. In other words, for understanding how client competence affects frontline employees' willingness to help clients, it may be relevant to simultaneously consider client motivation (and vice versa).

For the purpose of clarity, we conceptualize the possible constellations of variation in clients' competence and motivation in terms of four stylized client types: lazy novice, lazy expert, diligent novice, and diligent expert. As table 1 shows, lazy novice denotes a client exhibiting low competences and low motivation while diligent expert denotes a client exhibiting high competences and high motivation. Lazy expert denotes high competences and low motivation while diligent novice denotes low competences and high motivation.

		Client competence	
		Low	High
Client motivation	Low	Lazy novice	Lazy expert
	High	Diligent novice	Diligent expert

Table 1 Client Types

Imagine a baseline situation in which a frontline employee perceives a client as a lazy novice (incompetent and unmotivated). According to the state-agent perspective, a frontline employee is expected to be more inclined to help lazy experts because these clients are more competent and, therefore, more likely to succeed. Similarly, according to the citizen-state perspective, we expect a frontline employee to be more inclined to help diligent novices because these clients are more motivated and, therefore, more deserving of extra help. Therefore, we hypothesize the following:

> **Hypothesis 1:** Frontline employees are more willing to exert an extra effort helping clients who are competent but unmotivated (lazy experts) compared to clients who are incompetent and unmotivated (lazy novices).

> **Hypothesis 2:** Frontline employees are more willing to exert an extra effort helping clients who are motivated but incompetent (diligent novices) compared to clients who are incompetent and unmotivated (lazy novices).

What is the more important client attribute of the two? As mentioned, the answer may depend on the relative strength of the two narratives among frontline employees in the given context. Still, even state agents are likely reluctant to prioritize lazy experts because these clients' lack of motivation decreases the likelihood of policy success. Citizen agents, however, are likely widely unaffected by clients' competence because this attribute is not directly related to clients' overall level of perceived deservingness. Therefore, we hypothesize the following:

> **Hypothesis 3:** Frontline employees are more willing to exert an extra effort helping clients who are motivated but incompetent (diligent novices) compared to clients who are competent but unmotivated (lazy experts).

Finally, clients may be both competent and motivated. Assuming that a combination of the state-agent and citizen-agent perspectives influences frontline employees' behavior, we expect that they are most willing to help diligent experts because these clients are more likely to succeed and seen as more deserving of help. This leads to our fourth and final hypothesis:

> **Hypothesis 4:** Frontline employees are most willing to exert an extra effort helping clients who are both competent and motivated (diligent experts).

Methods

Setting

This article tests the hypotheses using a sample of public caseworkers dealing with unemployed citizens in Denmark. Similar to frontline employees in other public service organizations, caseworkers face situations of high demands for service and limited available resources (Soss, Fording, and Schram 2011). The Danish unemployment service is organized in 94 municipal job centers. To receive unemployment benefits, unemployed citizens are obligated

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to sign up at these centers. At the job centers, caseworkers assist clients in finding employment. For example, caseworkers may assign clients to internships or job training programs that help clients become more attractive job candidates. Whereas the job training programs are often expensive, assignments to the internships are rare but in high demand among unemployed individuals because they provide a better opportunity for future employment. Consequently, because of a limited amount of resources and a low supply of internships, caseworkers have to prioritize which clients to provide with job training programs and which clients to recommend for internships.

The central government partly compensates the municipalities (responsible for the job centers) for the costs of unemployment benefits through refunds. The compensation covers 80 percent of the costs for the first four weeks of unemployment. Afterward, the size of the refund gradually drops toward 20 percent at the end of the first year of unemployment. However, although the municipalities are incentivized to get unemployed clients into employment quickly, the incentive does generally not have a trickle-down effect to the payment of caseworkers (as a group or individually).

Research Design

Ideally, we would randomly assign caseworkers to individual cases that are identical except for variation in client competence and motivation and then observe how much time and effort caseworkers spend on each case. However, because no two real-life cases are identical, the research reported in this article tests the hypotheses using a 2 × 2 factorial survey experiment. This approach enables testing the effects of client motivation and competence on caseworkers' willingness to help particular clients. Yet, as in most survey experiments (e.g., Andersen and Guul 2019; Jilke and Tummers 2018; Pedersen, Stritch, and Thuesen 2018; Schram et al. 2009), the design is limited by measurement of behavioral intent rather than actual behavior (we will discuss the limitations of our design in greater length later).

The design involves a stylized description of an unemployed client. Manipulating the client's job competence (low-high) and job motivation (low-high), we operate with four distinct treatment combinations as noted previously, each signifying a hypothetical client exhibiting a distinct combination of competence and motivation. As shown in table 1, we refer to the four treatment combinations as lazy novice, lazy expert, diligent novice, and diligent expert.

We took several steps for ensuring the realism of our approach. First, we use a between-subject design in which we asked each caseworker to evaluate a single client. We recognize the efficiency of within-subject designs in terms of power and minimizing random noise. However, within-subject designs are also susceptible to potential learning bias and transfer across conditions. We presented caseworkers to a single client (instead of asking them to, say, prioritize between two clients) as to best reflect how real-life caseworkers work and interact with clients. In contrast to teachers who engage with a classroom of students, caseworkers engage with clients one at a time. We are essentially interested in how caseworkers prioritize the time and effort spent on each client, not how they prioritize directly among clients. Second, when assessing clients, caseworkers have access to a multitude of relevant information about clients. Therefore, we constructed a vignette describing an unemployed client on unemployment benefits that involved a relatively lengthy description of background information (e.g., the client's unemployment history, family situation, and personal challenges). The additional client information reduces the treatment intensity of our experimental manipulation of client competence and motivation—providing, in turn, a tougher, more conservative test. Third, we embedded the cues about the client's competence and motivation in an evaluation from an employer of a short internship, a realistic way for caseworkers to receive information about clients. We made tangible claims about how the client had fared during the internship, signaling competence or incompetence and a motivated or unmotivated attitude. In particular, our competence cues relate to variation in clients' technical and cognitive skills (low versus high) for accomplishing the designated internship work tasks. Ability-Motivation-Opportunity theory (Kellner, Cafferkey, and Townsend 2019) suggests that work performance is a function of an interactive relationship between an individual's work ability, work motivation, and the opportunities to enact his or her ability and motivation at work—with technical and cognitive skills constituting the key parts of the "ability" component. Our motivation cues relate to variation in the client's general work engagement and motivation (low versus high). In terms of self-determination theory (Deci and Ryan 2000), our cues tap into the conceptual difference between "amotivation" (i.e., a lack of intention and motivation) and regulation in the form of both extrinsic and intrinsic motivation (i.e., types of motivation involving both intentionality and motivation). The cues were formulated to substantiate differences in the client's competence and motivation while ensuring that the information was provided in a credible and realistic way. Supporting this notion, an experienced caseworker confirmed the contextual realism of the vignette. Table 2 shows the operationalization.

To minimize the risk of bias caused by correlation of client names with ethnic or social status (Jilke and Tummers 2018), that is, first names associated with stereotypes, we referred to the client as "X." In addition, we randomized the gender of the client to minimize the risk of confounding due to gender interplay with the relevant attributes. The full vignette appears in table 3.

As our outcome measure, we asked caseworkers to report the likelihood that they would use additional time and effort helping the client on a scale from 0 to 10. We reminded the caseworkers that providing extra help to the client would mean less time for helping other clients.

We included two simple manipulation checks (one for motivation and one for competence) at the end of the survey. Both checks support the finding that the treatment conditions affected the respondents' perception of both the client's competence and motivation in the expected direction (see the appendix, table A2, for more information).[3]

Data Collection

We embedded the survey experiment in an electronic survey. We acquired caseworkers' email addresses through contact with all 94 job center managers in Denmark. In total, 44 job centers

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provided the requested email addresses,[4] while 6 job centers agreed to participate but asked for an "open link" for the distribution of the survey. Restricting the sample to caseworkers about whom we received direct contact information does not change the results substantially.

We collected the data in November 2017 through January 2018. A total of 1,595 caseworkers participated. Because we did not know the number of caseworkers in the six job centers not providing us with direct contact information, we were unable to calculate an exact response rate. The response rate was 47 percent among the job centers providing direct contact information. Because one (large) job center provided a full list of all employees (not only caseworkers), we consider the 47 percent to be a conservative estimate.

We carefully considered the ethics of our data collection approach. Importantly, the managers consented to the caseworkers' participation. We asked the managers to encourage their caseworkers to participate, but we did not inform the managers about which caseworkers actually participated, and the caseworkers could therefore choose not to do so. In addition, we informed the caseworkers that all results would be disclosed in an anonymous format, which was enforced, and we did not share the caseworkers' responses with their managers. Finally, we debriefed the caseworkers, emphasizing that the vignette was fictional and that the purpose of the study was to examine how caseworkers prioritize their time at work.

Table 2 Operationalization of Competence and Motivation

Competence (Low)	Competence (High)
X to a **small** degree had the necessary competences to accomplish these tasks. For instance, X has found it **difficult** to operate the machine, has made **disproportionately many** mistakes, and has found it **difficult** to keep track of what X had to get done before closing time.	X to a **large** degree had the necessary competences to accomplish these tasks. For instance, X has found it **easy** to operate the machine, has made **very few** mistakes, and has found it **easy** to keep track of what X had to get done before closing time.
Motivation (Low)	**Motivation (High)**
The employer also says that X has seemed very **unmotivated** throughout the entire trainee period. X has had **an uncommitted** approach to the tasks and has generally shown **little** interest in the work.	The employer also says that X has seemed very **motivated** throughout the entire trainee period. X had **a committed** approach to the tasks and generally showed **great** interest in the work.

Notes: Randomized cues in bold font.

Table 3 The Vignette

X is a 33-year-old man/woman. X lives with his/her partner who is enrolled in an education program. They have two children together. X is assessed as job ready.

X left middle school after the ninth grade and has not completed any education since then. X was a cleaner for several years but experienced depression three years ago, which led to a long sick leave. After the sick leave, X fell out of the unemployment benefits system and now receives cash benefits. Because of the period of illness, X experienced cognitive challenges maintaining concentration and control. X is now fit to return to work but has had difficulties finding a new job.

X has recently been in trainee placement four days a week for four weeks. The trainee period took place in a manufacturing company where X operated a machine and helped stock the warehouse. The employer from the company says that X had to a [large/small] degree of the necessary competences to accomplish these tasks. For instance, X found it [easy/difficult] to operate the machine, made [very few/disproportionately many] mistakes, and found it [easy/difficult] to keep track of what she/he had to get done before closing time. The employer also says that X seemed very [motivated/unmotivated] throughout the entire trainee period. X had [a committed/an uncommitted] approach to the tasks and generally showed [great/little] interest in the work.

As a caseworker, you may be exposed to a considerable caseload. How likely is it that you would make an extra effort to help X get a job? Assume that an extra effort means that you have a little less time to help other clients.

Results

Descriptive Statistics

Table 4 shows that the respondents balance well on observable covariates across levels of the two treatments. One exemption is the gender of the client in the vignette. However, because we determined the status of client gender by randomization, this variable should not be associated with other relevant characteristics. Still, we ran robustness analyses with control for client gender. Table 4 also shows the raw (unadjusted) outcome score for the full sample (mean = 7.36; SD = 2.03). Finally, the table shows the pooled means (and standard deviations): expert (mean = 7.51; SD = 2.08), novice (mean = 7.21; SD = 1.96), diligent (mean = 7.68; SD = 1.95), and lazy (mean = 7.02; SD = 2.05).

Table 4 Descriptive Statistics by Treatments and for the Full Sample

	Competence				Motivation				Full sample	
	Expert		Novice		Diligent		Lazy			
	Mean	SD	Mean	SD	Mean	SD	Mean	SD	Mean	SD
Female share [0;1]	.82		.81		.83		.81		.82	
Female share (missing) [0;1]	.02		.01		.02		.01		.02	
Age, years [natural coding]	44.72	11.74	44.43	11.27	44.49	11.41	44.67	11.62	44.58	11.51
Age, years (missing) [0;1]	.02		.01		.02		.01		.01	
Experience, years [natural coding]	7.54	6.81	7.63	6.79	7.59	6.72	7.58	6.88	7.59	6.80
Experience, years (missing) [0;1]	.02		.01		.02		.01		.01	
Caseload, no. of cases [natural coding]	61.86	51.75	62.91	56.57	63.62	58.89	61.10	48.83	62.37	54.14
Caseload, no. of cases (missing) [0;1]	.26		.25		.25		.25		.25	
Client female share [0;1]	.47		.51		.47		.51		.49	
Willingness to help[0;10]	7.51	2.08	7.21	1.96	7.68	1.95	7.02	2.05	7.36	2.03
Observations assigned to treatment	921		872		906		887		1,793	
Observations responded to treatment	813		782		823		772		1,595	
Response rate [0;100]	88.27		89.68		90.84		87.03		88.96	

Notes: Joint F-test shows no significant differences (at $p < .05$) on baseline covariates or response rate (for those assigned to a survey experimental treatment) but significant differences for age missing (though the absolute difference is negligible), Client female share and the outcome measure (willingness to help).

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Effects of Competence and Motivation

We tested our hypotheses using a single statistical inferential framework: All main results are based on an ordinary least squares (OLS) model specification regressing the respondents' "willingness to help" on two binary variables, one for each factor (competence and motivation), and an interaction term variable (Competence × Motivation).[5] In particular, based on this model specification, we used marginal linear prediction to estimate the *main effects* for each factor (i.e., the average effects both for novice versus expert and for lazy versus diligent), the *interaction effect* between the two factors, and the *simple effects* (i.e., the differences in outcome responses for each pairwise constellation of treatment combinations). Table 5, model 1, shows the results (the underlying OLS model specification appears in the appendix, table A1, model 1).

We found that both factors have a significant main effect (at $p < .05$). The main effect for competence is −0.28 (Cohen's $d = 0.14$), suggesting that caseworkers are less willing to help clients who are novices (relative to experts). Similarly, the main effect for motivation is −0.65 (Cohen's $d = 0.32$), suggesting that caseworkers are less willing to help clients who are lazy (relative to diligent). The difference in main effects is significant (at $p < .01$). This result indicates support for H3: that motivation may be a more important client attribute than competence for caseworkers' willingness to help. Moreover, we found no evidence of an interaction effect between motivation and competence (at $p < .05$), thus rejecting the notion that the effect of client competence on caseworkers' willingness to help their clients is moderated by client motivation (and vice versa).

Table 5 Main Effects, Interaction Effect, and Simple Effects of Treatments on Willingness to Help (0–10)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Main effects					
Competence (novice)	−.28**	−.29**	−.27**	−.27*	−.26*
	(.10)	(.10)	(.10)	(.10)	(.10)
Motivation (lazy)	−.65***	−.66***	−.65***	−.64***	−.63***
	(.09)	(.09)	(.08)	(.09)	(.08)
Interaction Effect					
Competence (novice)×Motivation (lazy)	.22	.23	.19	.18	.15
	(.23)	(.23)	(.23)	(.23)	(.23)
Simple effects					
Lazy novice vs. Lazy expert	−.17	−.17	−.18	−.18	−.18
	(.18)	(.18)	(.18)	(.18)	(.18)
Lazy novice vs. Diligent novice	−.54***	−.55***	−.56***	−.55***	−.56***
	(.13)	(.13)	(.13)	(.13)	(.13)
Lazy novice vs. Diligent expert	−.93***	−.94***	−.92***	−.91***	−.89***
	(.14)	(.14)	(.14)	(.14)	(.14)
Lazy expert vs. Diligent novice	.37**	.37**	.38**	.37**	.37**
	(.12)	(.13)	(.12)	(.12)	(.12)
Lazy expert vs. Diligent expert	−.76***	−.77***	−.75***	−.73***	−.71***
	(.15)	(.15)	(.15)	(.15)	(.15)
Diligent novice vs. Diligent expert	−.39**	−.40**	−.37**	−.36**	−.33**
	(.12)	(.12)	(.12)	(.12)	(.12)
Client female	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Covariates	No	No	Yes	No	Yes
Fixed effects	No	No	No	Yes	Yes

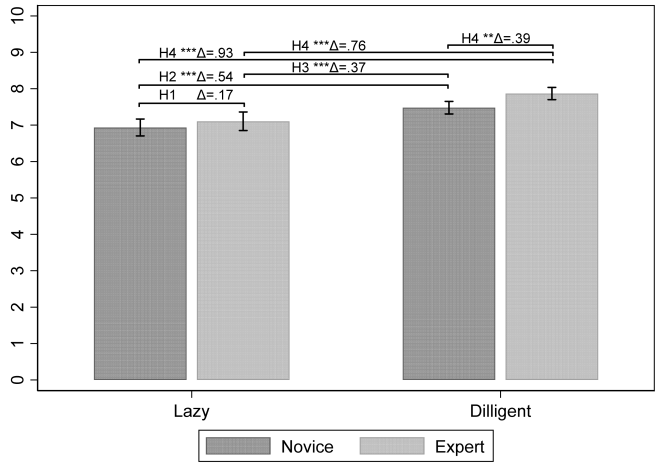
Notes: Coefficients and standard errors (in parentheses). n = 1,595. Main effects, interaction effect, and simple effects are based on marginal linear predictions of models (1–5) in table A1 in the appendix. Standard errors are clustered at job center level (in parentheses). Labels in parenthesis indicate level of variable equal to 1. Client female indicates whether client female indicator is included. Covariates indicate that the following caseworker characteristics are included: gender, age, experience, and caseload as well as missing variable indicators. Number of groups in fixed effects estimation is 50.
*$p < .05$, **$p < .01$, ***$p < .001$.

In support of H2, we found that client motivation matters for frontline employees' willingness to help clients. Caseworkers are more willing to help the diligent novice relative to the lazy novice (Cohen's $d = 0.28$). Caseworkers are also more willing to help the diligent novice at the expense of the lazy expert (Cohen's $d = 0.19$). Similar to the observed main effects, this finding supports H3, suggesting that motivation is a more important client attribute than competence when frontline employees help their clients. As previously discussed, a viable explanation for this result is the salient role that client motivation plays in both the state-agent and citizen-agent perspectives. It also shows that caseworkers are more willing to help the incompetent than the competent client when the latter is unmotivated.

Finally, we found support for H4. Caseworkers are most willing to help clients exhibiting competence and motivation (diligent experts) across our four treatment combinations (Cohen's $d = 0.47$ compared to the lazy novice). This finding indicates that frontline employees

The simple effects provide direct tests of our four hypotheses. Figure 1 provides a graphical illustration of our findings and shows the average level of willingness to help across treatment combinations (means = 6.94–7.86; standard deviations = 1.87–2.09).

The simple effect estimates do not support H1: Caseworkers are thus not more willing to help clients who are competent and unmotivated (lazy experts) than clients who are incompetent and unmotivated (lazy novices). The difference in willingness to help is statistically insignificant (at $p < .05$) and substantially negligible (Cohen's $d = 0.08$). This finding is at odds with the state-agent narrative predicting prioritization of lazy experts at the expense of lazy novices.



Notes: n = 1,595. Δ = Simple effects. Absolut difference between treatment combinations. The average willing to help for each treatment combinations is based on the OLS model estimates reported in table A1, model 1, in the appendix. Similarly, all simple effects are based on marginal linear predictions of the OLS model estimates reported in table 5, model 1. Descriptives for each treatment combination are lazy novice (mean = 6.94; SD = 2.01); lazy expert (mean = 7.11; SD = 2.09); diligent novice (mean = 7.48; SD = 1.87); diligent expert (mean = 7.86; SD = 2.00).
*$p < .05$ **$p < .01$***$p < .001$

Figure 1 Mean Willingness to Help (0–10) across Treatment Combinations (with 95% Confidence Intervals and Simple Effects)

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help the "easy-to-serve" clients at the expense of the other clients. The potential consequence of this behavior is that clients in the least need of help to succeed are prioritized at the expense of those in most need of help. We will return to this point in the conclusion.

Our findings may appear to indicate that the effect of client competence differs depending on client motivation, thus corroborating the notion of an interplay between client attributes. Indeed, caseworkers are more willing to help the competent client than the incompetent client when both are motivated (diligent novice versus diligent expert), which contrasts with the findings concerning competence when the competent client is unmotivated (i.e., we found no effect of competence for lazy novice versus lazy expert). In other words, competence has an effect when client motivation is high (at $p < .05$) but not when client motivation is low (at $p < .05$). As demonstrated by the (insignificant) interaction estimates, however, the difference between diligent novice and diligent expert is not statistically different from the difference between lazy novice and lazy expert (at $p < .05$).

To test the robustness of our findings, we have conducted analyses including covariates, an indicator for the random assignment of client gender and job center fixed effects. The results appear in table 5, models 2–5 (and in table A1, models 2–5, in the appendix). We have also tried adjusting the standard errors for multiple hypotheses testing with Bonferroni adjustment. None of these robustness tests substantially alters the main results—supporting the robustness of our findings.

Discussion of Limitations

The findings must be interpreted in light of limitations to our study's research design. The analyses are based on caseworker responses to a survey-experimental vignette and, therefore, have a strong claim to internal validity. Still, the size and significance of the effects we observed might be underestimated because of stochastic measurement errors in caseworkers' responses. Moreover, we captured would-be responses to a stylized vignette: behavioral intent rather than actual workplace behavior. Caseworkers' willingness to help clients in real-life settings may differ from their reported survey answers—and real-life expenditure of extra help to clients occurs based on more information than what is possible to convey through text in a survey vignette. Although we designed the vignette to increase contextual realism, the effects of clients' competence and motivation in and across real-life casework may differ from our results. Several factors may help lessen this concern. First, survey experiments are arguably less biased by social desirability than standard survey formats (Andersen and Guul 2019). Second, and in line with this notion, a recent study among the same population as ours shows that survey-experimental evidence provides results similar to analysis based on administrative data (Pedersen, Stritch, and Thuesen 2018).

Finally, our sample may not fully represent the full population of Danish unemployment caseworkers. Those in our sample may differ from those who did not participate. Importantly, this concern does not diminish the internal validity of our study. However, it does raise questions about the generalizability of our findings. We have no substantive reason to suspect our general model to be largely nongeneralizable to other groups of frontline employees, policy areas, and countries. However, the relative importance of the citizen-agent and state-agent narratives possibly differ, and, therefore, the exact caseworker behavior might differ as well. Thus, we recognize that whether our findings apply in other settings and situations is an empirically open question. Related to this latter point, we acknowledge that our specific operationalization of competence and motivation might have affected our findings—as in all experimental setups. Specifically, our treatments may not be perceived as having equal intensity. The ideal would be to examine a broad range of operationalizations. However, as caseworkers' time is a limited resource, we chose to prioritize a reasonably well-powered test of our most promising operationalization validated through a qualitative pilot study rather than risking committing a type 2 error (i.e., failure to reject a false null hypothesis).

Conclusion

This article expands our knowledge about how client attributes affect frontline employees' willingness to help clients. Using an experimental vignette design among more than 1,500 unemployment caseworkers, we show how two generic nondemographic client attributes influence frontline employees' willingness to exert extra time and effort helping a client. In line with Jilke and Tummers (2018), we found that client motivation (effort) and client competence (performance) both affect frontline employees' willingness to help a client. Caseworkers are increasingly willing to help clients exhibiting high competence and high motivation. Moreover, but in contrast to Jilke and Tummers (2018), our findings also indicate that client motivation is a more important factor than client competence for caseworkers' willingness to help a client.

We believe that our results differ from those of Jilke and Tummers (2018) for several reasons. First, the context of the decision is different. Jilke and Tummers (2018) study teachers who usually interact with students in classroom settings. Therefore, teachers' time and effort prioritization often relates directly to the choice between two or more students. In contrast, caseworkers usually review and assess one client at a time, that is, interact with clients strictly in one-on-one meetings—a distinction suggested as important in previous studies (Guul 2018). Second, the nature of the policy goals is different. Whereas the policy goal for unemployment service—getting the client back in employment—is dichotomous, relatively singular, and unambiguous, the area of schooling is characterized by multiple and potentially conflicting goals (e.g., that all students achieve a sufficient level of academic skills, experience challenge and progression, thrive emotionally, and develop into democratic citizens). Finally, the difference may be a consequence of interplay between the two attributes. Indeed, we found that incompetent but motivated clients are prioritized over competent but unmotivated clients, and the estimated main effect for motivation is larger than that for competence.

Although we did not identify an interaction effect, we encourage more research to examine the interplay between client attributes in how frontline employees' judgments and decision-making is shaped. Our failure to reject the null is not the same as validation of the null, and more research on how different attributes may enlarge or reduce the effects of other attributes is needed.

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In sum, our results have important implications for our understanding of how we should study coping mechanisms and deservingness heuristics at the frontline of public service delivery. Our results demonstrate how both creaming behavior and deservingness heuristics influence frontline employees' behavior and decision-making. Although the relative weight of the state-agent and citizens-agent perspectives may be context dependent, they are simultaneously at work, and both perspectives should be considered when examining frontline employees' behavior and decision-making.

The limitations of the study call for future research seeking to replicate our findings. In line with recent calls for increasing scholarly attention to replication endeavors (Pedersen and Stritch 2018; Walker et al. 2018), future studies should examine the extent to which our findings hold over variations in persons, settings, and situations. We also encourage further research into the interplay between particular aspects of clients' competence and motivation. For example, are clients exhibiting high competence and intrinsic motivation perceived as more deserving than comparable clients exhibiting more extrinsic motivation?

Another venue for future research relates to the implications of our study for practice. So what? Why should we care about frontline employees' willingness to help clients and the ways that clients' competence and motivation shape employee behavior? We contend that frontline employees' willingness to exert extra time and effort helping a client based on a caseworker's perception of clients' competence and motivation is not supported by formal policy rules and regulations and may result in unequal treatment of individual citizens. In many areas of public service delivery, a client's competence and motivation do not constitute legitimate grounds for provision of extra assistance or benefit to the client. We recognize that prioritization of clients might be a feasible strategy for improving agency performance and that some policy areas are marked by procedures—formal or informal—allowing frontline employees to help some clients more than others. However, these procedures will typically prescribe a prioritization of clients who are most in need. In contrast to our findings, we are not aware of any areas of public service in which more help to clients who are most likely to do well or succeed is justified by policy rules or regulations.

Our study therefore encourages public decision-makers to be aware of the potential presence of client prioritization bias in their organization's services delivery and (inasmuch as an equal treatment of clients is desired) to actively seek to minimize the risk that the citizens "most in need" are deprioritized in favor of those who are "the least in need" (i.e., the competent and motivated). Research plays a vital role in the realization of this agenda: In addition to replicating our findings, future studies should seek to identify tangible interventions that effectively curb the occurrence of creaming. For inspiration, the limited but increasing body of debiasing research may serve as a useful starting point (Morewedge et al. 2015; Nasie et al. 2014; Petersen 2019; Schwartz et al. 2010, 2014). Ultimately, whether all citizens should be entitled to a fair and equal treatment in their dealings with government and public services is a political question. However, concern about fairness and equity is often a main argument for delivering services in a public rather than private context (Boyne et al. 2003). According to core administrative principles of equity and impartiality, citizens who are more competent and motivated should not receive extra benefits or services at the expense of those who are less so.

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Notes

1. These concepts are also linked to the broader justice concepts of ability (competence) and effort (motivation) (e.g., see Bénabou and Tirole 2006).
2. How, exactly, may interdependency between client characteristics help explain why the effect of a particular client attribute is found to differ across studies? We suggest that a partial reason for differing effects of a given client attribute X1 across studies may be due to an unobserved client attribute X2. For example, say that two studies examine the effects of client attribute X1. Client attribute X2 moderates the effects of client attribute X1, but X2 is unobserved in both studies. Study 1 finds a positive effect; study 2 does not. We note that this difference may refer to a difference in the distribution of the sample respondents' client attribute X2 in the two studies. Taking account of the interdependency between client characteristics X1 and X2—for example, by means interaction effects analyses—is thus appropriate.
3. The motivation treatment also significantly affected the perception of the client's competence. However, the effect appears small and negligible (the coefficient is only 1/20 in magnitude of the effect of the competence treatment on the perception of client competence).
4. One job center provided contact information on a subsample of its caseworkers.
5. Replication files are available on Harvard Dataverse: https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/ZUOSR8. All covariates are excluded for reasons of discretion. Thus, the files does not allow for replication of table 4 and model 3 and 5 in tables 5 and A1.

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Appendix

Table A1 Effects of Competence and Motivation on Mean Willingness to Help (0–10)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Competence (novice)	−.39**	−.40**	−.37**	−.36**	−.33**
	(.12)	(.12)	(.12)	(.12)	(.12)
Motivation (lazy)	−.76***	−.77***	−.75***	−.73***	−.71***
	(.15)	(.15)	(.15)	(.15)	(.15)
Competence (novice)×Motivation (lazy)	.22	.23	.19	.18	.15
	(.23)	(.23)	(.23)	(.23)	(.23)
Client female		.15	.16	.15	.16
		(.10)	(.10)	(.10)	(.10)
Constant	7.87***	7.80***	6.72***	7.77***	6.74***
	(.08)	(.10)	(.22)	(.08)	(.21)
Observations	1,595	1,595	1,595	1,595	1,595
Covariates	No	No	Yes	No	Yes
Fixed effects	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Adjusted R^2	.03	.03	.05	.03	.05

Notes: OLS Regression. Coefficients and Standard Errors (in parentheses). Standard errors are clustered at job center level (in parentheses). Labels in parentheses indicate level of variable equal to 1. All reported variables are indicator variables. Client female indicates whether the described client was either male or female. The effect of client female is insignificant across specifications. Included covariates are the following caseworker characteristics: gender, age, experience, and caseload as well as missing variable indicators. Number of groups in fixed effects estimation is 50.
*p<.05, **p<.01, ***p<.001.

Table A2 Manipulation Check

	Competence Item	Motivation Item
Competence (novice)	−1.79***	−.10**
	(.04)	(.03)
Motivation (lazy)	.06	−2.14***
	(.05)	(.04)
Constant	4.22***	4.35***
	(.04)	(.03)
Observations	1,532	1,518
Adjusted R^2	.50	.62

Notes: OLS Regression. Standard errors clustered at job center level (in parentheses). Measures are based on two survey items: (1) "X seems to have the necessary competences to solve the tasks in the trainee placement" (competence) or (2) "X seems to be motivated to solve the tasks in the trainee placement" (motivation). 1 = Strongly disagree; 5 = Strongly agree. The questions were asked at the end of the survey.
*p<.05, **p<.01, ***p<.001.

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